Repertoires of Sexual Violence during Armed Conflict

1989-2015 Data Package

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1.0 Introduction

Recent scholarship has established that the frequency of rape of civilians by armed combatants during conflict varies sharply (Wood 2006, 2009; Cohen 2013, 2016; Cohen and Nordås 2014). That sexual violence by armed combatants during conflict varies dramatically in its form has not been systematically documented and analyzed to the same extent. Causes of sexual violence are likely to vary with the specific form – rape during combat operations, for example, is likely driven by different mechanisms than forced marriage or abortion. Social science theory seeking to explain variation in wartime sexual violence should therefore analyze its specific forms. Such variation is also important because accountability is deepened when specific patterns of victimization are recognized by truth commissions and prosecuted in national or international courts, and because interventions during conflict as well as victim support post-conflict are likely to be more effective if tailored to those specific patterns.

The Repertoires of Sexual Violence during Armed Conflict (RSVAC) Data Package consists of a dataset (including extensive qualitative notes), conflict manuscripts (compiling the relevant sections of the source documents), and this codebook. The dataset summarizes the reported *repertoire* – the reported forms of sexual violence at different prevalence levels – perpetrated by conflict actors in interstate and intra-state armed conflicts each year from 1989 to 2015. The RSVAC project is an extension of the Sexual Violence in Armed Conflict (SVAC) dataset (Cohen & Nordås, 2014). RSVAC disaggregates the reported prevalence of eight forms of sexual violence: rape, sexual slavery and forced marriage, forced prostitution, forced sterilization and abortion, forced pregnancy, sexual mutilation, non-penetrative sexual torture, and sexual abuse – for each actor and year, along with qualitative notes concerning victims, targeting, location, and other contextual details.

The RSVAC Data Package (dataset, codebook, conflict manuscripts) adopts the scope and units of observation of the SVAC dataset (Cohen & Nordås, 2014) updated to 2015. Hence, we include the same armed conflicts, actors, and years (including up to five interim and post-conflict years; see below for additional information). However, in the SVAC dataset, where an actor was reported to have engaged in more than one form of sexual violence in a conflict-actor-year, the prevalence value is based on the magnitude of whichever form was reportedly perpetrated most widely, whereas in the RSVAC dataset, where an actor was reported to have engaged in more than one form of sexual violence in a conflict-actor-year, we provide a measure of reported prevalence for each form.

Qualitative comparison of repertoires and targeting, or identification of relevant cases for in-depth analysis will often be the most appropriate uses of the data package. Observational challenges in sexual violence research can be particularly pronounced in a disaggregated approach. Scholars should therefore consider possible limitations and underreporting in the data before any statistical applications, and explicitly discuss and qualify empirical results with those caveats. In discussing the dataset, we consistently refer to *reported* prevalence, not the true levels of abuse.

1.1 Background on SVAC dataset

The SVAC dataset measures the prevalence of sexual violence at the conflict-actor-year level using an ordinal scale, with 0 indicating no reported sexual violence and the highest score, 3, indicating reports of massive sexual violence. A separate prevalence variable is coded for each of the sources used to create the dataset: the annual U.S. State Department "Country Report on Human Rights Practices," along with annual reports and special topical reports published by Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch. The SVAC dataset also includes a variable that captures the reported forms of sexual violence committed by actors.

The SVAC dataset includes all active armed conflicts from the UCDP/PRIO Armed Conflict Database (Gleditsch et al. 2002) and the UCDP Dyadic Dataset (Harbom, Melander & Wallensteen 2009; Harbom & Wallensteen 2010). Accordingly, to constitute an armed conflict the contested incompatibility – whether intrastate armed conflict, internationalized internal armed conflict, or interstate conflict – must reach at least 25 battle-related deaths. The SVAC dataset includes "interim years" and five "post-conflict years" to investigate how lapses in or a termination of active hostilities affects sexual violence. As defined in the SVAC Coding Manual, interim years are "conflict-actor-years that are not active (meaning that they do not reach the 25 battle-related deaths threshold) if the observation in question is less than 5 years after an active observation, AND the conflict actor resumes to be active within 5 years after the last active year."[1] Post-conflict years are five conflict-actor-years after the last year that the conflict actor was deemed active.

Government/state forces, insurgent/rebel organizations, and other state actors from the UCDP/PRIO armed conflict data and the UCDP Dyadic Dataset are included in the SVAC dataset. The SVAC dataset also includes pro-government militias from the Pro-Government Militias (PGMs) Dataset (Carey and Mitchell 2013).[2]

For additional information on SVAC project, including the dataset and Coding Manual, please see: http://www.sexualviolencedata.org/

1.2 The RSVAC extension

The RSVAC Data Package was created using the SVAC dataset and Conflict Manuscripts, which contain excerpts on sexual violence from the annual U.S. State Department "Country Report on Human Rights Practices" (USSD) and the annual reports and special topical reports published by Amnesty International (AI) and Human Rights Watch (HRW). A human coder read the SVAC Conflict Manuscripts, and recorded relevant excerpts into new RSVAC Conflict Manuscripts, checking the original source if necessary.

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[1] SVAC Coding Manual, http://www.sexualviolencedata.org/
[2] PGMs are included in the years 1989-2009 only.

For particular judgments on how to define an act of sexual violence, the coder recorded their rationale as a note in the RSVAC Conflict Manuscript. Reports of rape, sexual slavery, and sexual abuse are often declaratory (the form is explicitly named in the source), whereas reports of sexual mutilation and non-penetrative sexual torture are often descriptive, meaning the source reporting describes an act of violence, and the coder classifies the perpetrator's act in accordance with the RSVAC definitions.

The RSVAC dataset takes as its starting point all SVAC observations (conflict-actor-year) with non-zero sexual violence prevalence values. The RSVAC dataset uses the SVAC `form` variable to organize dataset observations into worksheets of the RSVAC workbook, where each worksheet features one of eight forms. The worksheet contains observations of the given form and variables to measure the reported prevalence of that form, along with qualitative notes on the context of incidents.

We employ the ordinal prevalence scale and coding conventions used in the SVAC dataset (Cohen & Nordås 2014) and by Cohen (2013). The ordinal categories indicate whether there were no reports (0) or reports of (1) isolated, (2) numerous, or (3) massive numbers of occurrences of that form of sexual violence on the part of each actor and each year based on each source separately (USSD, HRW, and AI). This results in twenty-four prevalence variables (three sources, eight forms).

Additionally, eight prevalence variables (one for each form) and a qualitative note field record reported violence by multiple perpetrators. These variables are coded on an ordinal scale: no reports (0), isolated reports (1), or significant reports (2). The code 2 indicates that multiple perpetrator incidents were reported in one or more of the three sources to have occurred relatively commonly, frequently, or regularly. The scale differs from the form-prevalence variables because the sources rarely provide detailed accounts of its frequency. A qualitative note field at each conflict-actor-year summarizes the reporting.

An important aspect of the RSVAC Data Package is the extensive qualitative notes that report additional information in the source material (context and details). Five fields of qualitative notes for each form give information on: (1) victim characteristics, (2) targeting, (3) attack timing, (4) attack location, and (5) witnesses.

The RSVAC Conflict Manuscripts contain direct quotations from the three sources (USSD, HRW, AI) for every year in the dataset with reports of multiple forms of sexual violence. The documents have searchable headers that are organized by actor, year, and source, and include passages on sexual violence that were coded as well as those that were not. Observations with non-zero prevalence values are accompanied by a table documenting the precise term or phrase underlying the coding decision. Several Conflict Manuscripts are hundreds of pages long.

2.0 Sexual Violence Definitions

The RSVAC dataset contains systematic information on the reported prevalence of eight forms of sexual violence: rape, sexual slavery and forced marriage, forced prostitution, forced sterilization and abortion, forced pregnancy, sexual mutilation, non-penetrative sexual torture, and sexual abuse.[3] Drawing boundaries between different forms of sexual violence is challenging. We therefore code some very related forms together in the dataset, mainly to avoid conceptual overlap between categories.

We coded an act as a particular form of sexual violence if the act is named as such in the source material or described with sufficient detail to enable categorization. Accordingly, general reports of "sexual violence," "sexual attacks," or other broad descriptors are not coded. For this and other reasons (discussed in the RSVAC article) our measures sometimes underestimate sexual violence prevalence.

See Table 1 in the RSVAC article for a summary of the sexual violence definitions.

2.1 Rape

Drawing on the International Criminal Court's definition, rape is defined as the case where the perpetrator invaded the body of a person by conduct resulting in penetration, however slight, of any part of the body of the victim or of the perpetrator with a sexual organ, or of the anal or genital opening of the victim with any object or any other part of the body.[4] The invasion was committed by force, or by threat of force or coercion, such as that caused by fear of violence, duress, detention, psychological oppression or abuse of power, against such person or another person, or by taking advantage of a coercive environment, or the invasion was committed against a person incapable of giving genuine consent.

We code an act of violence as rape when the act (1) meets the above definition and (2) does not conform to an alternative classification, such as sexual slavery, forced prostitution, or forced pregnancy. In the case where the evidence indicates repeated perpetration of rape as a feature of sexual slavery, an alternative classification (sexual slavery) is appropriate and sexual slavery alone is coded. Note that it was often not difficult to determine whether an act of violence should be classified as rape or an alternative form because the sources specified the form, or the sources reported sufficient details of the incident to classify the act. For those cases in which the coder made a judgment on how to define an act of sexual violence, the coder's rationale can be found as a note in the Conflict Manuscript.

We code an act as rape if the nature of the bodily harm conforms to the above definition regardless of how the source defines the act. Sources sometimes describe object rape as "sexual torture" but the act meets our definition of rape and is coded as such.

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[3] The SVAC dataset's definition of sexual violence included these same forms except for sexual abuse, which the SVAC dataset coded together with sexual torture.

[4] ICC, "Elements of Crimes", Document No. ICC-PIDS-LT-03-002/11_Eng, The Hague, 2011, Art. 8 (2) (b) (xxii)-1, available at: http://www.icc-cpi.int/NR/rdonlyres/336923D8-A6AD-40EC-AD7B-45BF9DE73D56/0/ElementsOfCrimesEng.pdf.

Example

Actor: **Turkey**
Country & Year: Turkey 1993
Form: Rape

> *Torture by police or gendarmes (soldiers carrying out police duties in rural areas) continued to be reported from all parts of Turkey, particularly the major cities and the southeast. Detainees suspected of links with illegal armed organizations were held for up to 30 days in incommunicado detention, unprotected by even the most basic safeguards against torture. In July Mitlik Ölmez was detained in the street by plainclothes police belonging to the Anti-Terror Branch. He was interrogated at Istanbul Police Headquarters for allegedly assisting the PKK: he said he was hung by the arms… **and had a truncheon repeatedly forced into his anus.** As a result, his arms became partially paralysed. A medical examination two weeks later, by the State Forensic Medicine Institute, found injuries consistent with his allegations.*[5]

Although this report describes the act as torture, we code the passage for rape.

2.2 Sexual slavery and forced marriage

Sexual slavery is defined as the case where the perpetrator exercised any or all of the powers attaching to the right of ownership over one or more persons, such as by purchasing, selling, lending or bartering such a person or persons, or by imposing on them a similar deprivation of liberty to cause such person or persons to engage in one or more acts of a sexual nature.

Evidence that a perpetrator placed a victim in captivity and raped the victim one or more times is insufficient to classify an act as sexual slavery. The evidence must indicate a deprivation of liberty that was continuous and ongoing and which could be construed as amounting to an assumption of ownership over the person. We accept that a perpetrator may have more than one motive for imposing a deprivation of liberty upon a person. To constitute sexual slavery the evidence must show that forcing the person to engage in acts of a sexual nature was at least one central reason for depriving such a person of his liberty.

Forced marriage is defined as the case where the perpetrator used force, or threat of force or coercion, to cause a person or persons to enter a forced conjugal association. The perpetrator's declaration to confer a status of marriage is sufficient. The marital arrangement need not be registered or otherwise recognized by a governing body for the forced conjugal relation to constitute marriage.[6] We consider an act to be forced marriage

[5] Amnesty International, Annual Report 1994, 1 January 1994, available at: https://www.amnesty.org/en/documents/pol10/0002/1994/en/

[6] See Gekker, Elena. "Rape, Sexual Slavery, and Forced Marriage at the International Criminal Court: How Katanga Utilizes a Ten-Year-Old Rule but Overlooks New Jurisprudence." *Hastings Women's Law*

if the source reports that the victim was the perpetrator's "wife" or "war bride," or if the source reports that the victim was "forcibly married" to the perpetrator. We assume that a forced marriage always entails sexual violence.

There must be unambiguous evidence that the bodily harm meets one of the above definitions for an incident to be coded as sexual slavery or forced marriage. The below passage was coded for rape, but not sexual slavery, because there was insufficient evidence that the kidnapped women were deprived of their liberty in a continuous and ongoing manner.

We code sexual slavery and forced marriage together, but in the qualitative notes preserves transparency about the specific coding decision and indicate which form (one or both) was reported in the conflict-actor-year (see below for additional information).

The following excerpt did not meet our definition of sexual slavery, as it lacked evidence of continuous and ongoing deprivation of liberty.

Example

Actor: **MFDC**
Country & Year: Senegal 1992
Form: Rape

> *In mid-1992, there were numerous reports of women being* ***kidnaped and raped*** *in the Casamance in connection with MFDC or bandit-related violence.*[7]

The below excerpt is a report that clearly met the definition of sexual slavery.

Example

Actor: **Indonesia**
Country & Year: Indonesia 1999
Form: Sexual slavery

> *Refugees interviewed by Amnesty International who had returned from Belu district to Dili in November 1999 also spoke of repeated incidents of rape. According to two refugees,* ***a number of women were held in sexual slavery*** *at the house of a TNI soldier in Rai Henek Oan near Betun. One of the women said to have been held there and repeatedly raped was Filomena Barbosa. Her sister was later told by a militia member that she had been killed sometime in mid October. The interviewee believed that Filomena Barbosa was specifically targeted because she had been active in the pro-independence campaign in East Timor.*[8]

Journal. See pages 128-132.
https://scholar.google.com/scholar?cluster=2159977695854671160&hl=en&as_sdt=0,33&sciodt=0,33

[7] United States Department of State, U.S. Department of State Country Report on Human Rights Practices 1992 - Senegal, 1993, available at: https://home.heinonline.org/

[8] Amnesty International, Indonesia/East Timor: No end to the crisis for East Timorese refugees , 1 December 1999, ASA 21/208/1999, available at: https://www.refworld.org/docid/45c21670f6.html

2.3 Forced prostitution

Forced prostitution is defined as the case where the perpetrator or another person obtained or expected to obtain pecuniary or other advantage in exchange for or in connection with the acts of a sexual nature.

2.4 Forced pregnancy

Forced pregnancy is defined as the case where the perpetrator confined one or more women forcibly made pregnant, with the intent of affecting the ethnic composition of any population or carrying out other grave violations of international law.

No instances of forced pregnancy were reported in our sources.

2.5 Forced abortion and forced sterilization

Forced sterilization and forced abortion is defined as the case where the perpetrator deprived one or more persons of biological reproductive capacity.

No instances of forced sterilization were reported in our sources.

2.6 Sexual mutilation

Sexual mutilation is defined as the case where permanent disfiguration of breasts, genitals, or anus has occurred and that this conduct, including but not limited to cutting/severing, has caused death or has seriously endangered the physical or mental health of such person or persons.

2.7 Sexual abuse

Sexual abuse is defined as the case where the perpetrator used force, or threat of force or coercion, to cause a person or persons to engage in sexual behavior or non-penetrating sexual contact.

We include sexual molestation and sexual assault in the definition of sexual abuse. We exclude sexual harassment, forced nudity, and any sexual act not involving direct force or physical contact. The precise meaning of sexual abuse, as it is used in the sources, is not always clear. Sources commonly report that an actor perpetrated “sexual abuse” without specifying the precise nature of the bodily harm. In these cases, we defer to the terminology used by the source, and code the act accordingly. The below example is emblematic of the term’s ambiguity. The passage is coded for sexual abuse.

Example

Actor: **FARC**
Country & Year: Colombia 1999
Form: Sexual abuse

The use of child soldiers by guerrillas was common, and paramilitary groups sometimes impressed children into their ranks. In May the FARC promised visiting Special Representative of the U.N. Secretary General on Children in Armed Conflict Olara Otunnu that it would stop forcing children into its ranks; however, it continued the practice. The Roman Catholic Church reported that the FARC lured or forced hundreds of children from the despeje zone into its ranks. It engaged in similar practices in other areas under its control. Once recruited, child guerrillas are virtual prisoners of their commanders and subject to various forms of abuse. ***Sexual abuse of girls is a particular problem.***[9]

The following excerpt was not coded because the harm was not sexual violence, according to the project's definitions. Forced nudity alone does not meet the definition of sexual torture or sexual abuse.

Example

Actor: **India**
Country & Year: India 1992
Form: None/Not coded

M. was taken to a nearby army hostel. At about 5:00 p.m. he was ***forced to strip naked*** *in the presence of eight army soldiers and two officers, one of whom was referred to as "Dedwal." They accused him of being a militant and ordered him to tell them the names of other militants. The soldiers beat him with lathis (canes) on his back and knees even after he fell to the floor. They forced him to swallow some alcohol. The soldiers pulled his legs apart at a wide angle, causing him great pain, and applied electric shocks to his wrists, ankles and toes.*[10]

2.8 Non-penetrative sexual torture

As defined by the United Nations Convention against Torture (CAT), "torture means any act by which severe pain or suffering, whether physical or mental, is intentionally inflicted on a person for such purposes as obtaining from him or a third person information or a confession, punishing him for an act he or a third person has committed or is suspected of having committed, or intimidating or coercing him or a third person, or for any reason based on discrimination of any kind, when such pain or suffering is inflicted by or at the instigation of or with the consent or acquiescence of a public official

[9] United States Department of State, U.S. Department of State Country Report on Human Rights Practices 1999 - Colombia , 25 February 2000, available at: https://www.refworld.org/docid/3ae6aa680.htm
[10] Human Rights Watch, Crackdown in Kashmir: Torture and Obstruction of Health Care, February 1993, available at: https://www.hrw.org/report/1993/01/01/crackdown-kashmir/torture-and-obstruction-health-care

or other person acting in an official capacity."[11] We include torture committed by non-state actors irrespective of state instigation, consent, or acquiescence.

As we seek to *disaggregate* forms of sexual violence, we define sexual torture narrowly as a residual category, even as we recognize that many acts we code as other forms surely count as sexual torture under a broader understanding. The CAT provision that torture may be "severe pain or suffering... intentionally inflicted... for any reason based on discrimination of any kind" necessarily includes acts that could be otherwise classified as rape, sexual slavery, sexual mutilation, or other forms of sexual violence. Consequently, in order to establish reasonably discrete definitions for each form of sexual violence, we code an act as sexual torture if it (1) meets the CAT definition and (2) cannot be classified under an alternative form. Non-penetrating acts, such as blows and electric shocks to sexual organs, were commonly coded as sexual torture.

In a limited number of cases, actors were reported to have inserted food or other irritants into a victim's vagina in order to cause pain. Penetration with an object meets our definition of rape yet using an irritant on a victim's genitalia appears to be more similar, both in intent and effect, to electric shocks or blows to genitalia than it does to object rape, and for this reason we coded penetration with irritants as sexual torture. The below example was coded for rape and sexual torture (inserting sticks and hot pepper in their vaginas).

Example

Actor: **RCD**
Country & Year: DRC (Zaire) 1999
Form: Sexual torture and rape

> *Though seemingly less frequently and systematically than the Hutu militia, RCD and RPA troops have also engaged in sexual violence, as in the attacks on Kilambo described above. Two women from Mwenga town described to Human Rights Watch researchers a particularly egregious use of sexual assault in torturing women prisoners there. According to their testimony, RCD troops under the command of Commander Frank Kasereka regularly beat and* ***raped*** *women in their custody,* ***sometimes inserting sticks and hot pepper in their vaginas.*** *According to one woman, who herself said she was detained and tortured by Kasereka's troops but who escaped their custody, "All the women were raped every day and beaten in the morning, in the early afternoon, and at night."*[12]

3.0 Sexual Violence Variables

[11] UN General Assembly, Convention Against Torture and Other Cruel, Inhuman or Degrading Treatment or Punishment, 10 December 1984, United Nations, Treaty Series, vol. 1465, p. 85, available at: https://www.refworld.org/docid/3ae6b3a94.html

[12] Human Rights Watch, Eastern Congo Ravaged: Killing Civilians and Silencing Protest, 1 May 2000, A1203, available at: http://www.unhcr.org/refworld/docid/3ae6a86e0.html

The RSVAC dataset has variables to capture the reported prevalence of each form of sexual violence, as well as variables capture the reported prevalence of incidents involving multiple perpetrators.

3.1 Measuring the prevalence of each form

We employ the prevalence measure and corresponding coding conventions used in the SVAC dataset. For each form, a separate prevalence variable is coded from each of the sources (USSD, AI, HRW). In sum:

Reported Prevalence of Sexual Violence:

3 = Massive
2 = Several/ many
1 = Some
0 = None reported
-99 = Missing information and report

Keywords from the source material dictate how to code prevalence. In detail:

Table 1. Prevalence Scores and Keywords

Prevalence	Keywords
	Per the sources, with regard to actor-perpetrated sexual violence in armed conflict, sexual violence was…, or was used by an actor as…, or occurred…, or there were…
3	"massive," "innumerable," or "systematic" "means of intimidation," "instrument of control and punishment," "weapon," "tactic to terrorize the population," "terror tactic," "tool of war," on a "massive scale" Reports of 1,000 or more incidents or victims of sexual violence
2	"widespread," "common," "commonplace," "extensive," "frequent," "often," "persistent," "recurring," a "pattern," a "common pattern," or a "spree" "commonly," "frequently," "in large numbers," "periodically," "regularly," "routinely," "widely," or on a "number of occasions;" there were "many" or "numerous instances" Reports of 25-999 incidents or victims of sexual violence

1	"reports," "isolated reports," or "there continued to be reports" Reports of less than 25 incidents or victims of sexual violence
0	No reported sexual violence
-99	No report and no information

Where the source reporting uses keywords that would allow more than one prevalence score, the highest possible is coded.

3.1.1 Sexual violence form variables

The RSVAC dataset has 24 variables to measure the prevalence of each form of sexual violence.

Table 2. Form Prevalence Variables

Form	Variables

Rape	`State_PrevRape`
	`AI_PrevRape`
	`HRW_PrevRape`

Forced prostitution	`State_PrevForcedPros`
	`AI_PrevForcedPros`
	`HRW_PrevForcedPros`

Forced abortion/ sterilization	`State_PrevForcedAbor`
	`AI_PrevForcedAbor`
	`HRW_PrevForcedAbor`

Sexual abuse	`State_PrevSexualAbus`
	`AI_PrevSexualAbus`
	`HRW_PrevSexualAbus`

Sexual slavery/ forced marriage	`State_PrevSexualSlav`
	`AI_PrevSexualSlav`
	`HRW_PrevSexualSlav`

Forced	`State_PrevForcedPreg`

pregnancy	`AI_PrevForcedPreg` `HRW_PrevForcedPreg`

Sexual mutilation	`State_PrevSexualMut`
	`AI_PrevSexualMut`
	`HRW_PrevSexualMut`

Non-penetrative sexual torture	`State_PrevSexualTor`
	`AI_PrevSexualTor`
	`HRW_PrevSexualTor`

Each set of prevalence variables (one set for each form) occupies its own worksheet in the RSVAC workbook. There are nine worksheets total, one for each form of sexual violence and one for the SVAC dataset.

3.1.2 Prevalence variable annotation: "See _____tab"

The SVAC dataset coded reports of sexual abuse and sexual molestation as forms of sexual torture whereas the RSVAC dataset uses a narrower definition of sexual torture and employs a separate prevalence variable for sexual abuse.

The observations in the RSVAC dataset were distributed across the RSVAC Data Package worksheets using the forms reported in the SVAC `form` variable (See Section 5.0 for additional information.). Due to the differing definitions of sexual torture in SVAC versus RSVAC, several observations on the sexual torture tab instruct users to "See sexual abuse tab" or "See sexual mutilation tab," indicating that the report that was classified as sexual torture in SVAC has been re-classified as an alternative form in RSVAC. In other words, what was once a sexual torture observation in SVAC is now a sexual abuse (or mutilation) observation in RSVAC. We use this notation to help preserve transparency of coding practices across SVAC and RVAC.

On the sexual torture worksheet, observations with this special notation in the `state_prevsexualtor` variable can be interpreted as zero (0) prevalence score for `state_prevsexualtor`, `ai_prevsexualtor`, and `hrw_prevsexualtor`. We use this notation because we want to highlight that the change in prevalence from SVAC to RSVAC is the result of differing definitions of sexual torture, and not an absence of reported sexual violence.

3.2 Measuring the prevalence of violence by multiple perpetrators

Eight prevalence variables record reported violence by multiple perpetrators. These variables are coded on an ordinal scale:

Prevalence of Multiple Perpetrator Sexual Violence	2 = Significant 1 = Reports/incidents 0 = None reported

If prevalence = 1, there were reports or isolated reports of multiple perpetrator sexual violence for the given form. Prevalence = 2 indicates that multiple perpetrator violence was reported to have occurred relatively commonly, frequently, or regularly. Observations with reports of multiple perpetrator violence are accompanied by a note describing the attack (See below for further information). Importantly, if prevalence = 2, the rationale for the higher magnitude score is included in this note. The scale used for multiple perpetrator variables differs from the form-prevalence variables (0-2 vs. 0-3) because the sources rarely provide detailed accounts of the frequency of multiple perpetrator violence.

Sexual violence involving multiple perpetrators is coded when there is clear evidence that two or more individuals were closely involved in the violence. All persons need not engage in sexual violence, but there must be evidence that two or more individuals made direct physical contact with the victim or were in the immediate physical proximity of the victim as a means to compel obedience or coercion at the time of the incident.

3.2.1 Multiple perpetrator variables

The RSVAC dataset contains one multiple perpetrator variable for each form of sexual violence. The variables were coded using all three sources (USSD, AI, HRW).

Table 3. Multiple Perpetrator Variables

Form	Variable
Rape	`MPRape`
Forced prostitution	`MPForcedPros`
Forced abortion/ sterilization	`MPForcedAbor`
Sexual abuse	`MPSexualAbus`
Sexual slavery/ forced marriage	`MPSexualSlav`
Forced pregnancy	`MPForcedPreg`
Sexual mutilation	`MPSexualMut`
Non-penetrative sexual torture	`MPSexualTor`

Each variable captures, for the given form, incidents of violence involving two or more perpetrators.

The following report was coded for sexual torture (squeezing sexual organs) and rape involving multiple perpetrators.

Example

Actor: **Turkey**
Country & Year: Turkey 2001
Form: Sexual Torture and rape

> *Mürsel Sargut was brought to the upper floor of the building where he was urged to "confess" to membership of the illegal armed opposition group Kurdistan Workers' Party (PKK) and of having helped organize a campaign by university students to request Kurdish language classes... When he refused, police officers reportedly beat and slapped him.*
>
> *Later in the day, after having been taken to hospital for a medical inspection, he was brought back to detention at the Anti-Terror Branch of Istanbul Police Headquarters. There he was reportedly exposed to torture and ill-treatment* ***by three or four police officers.*** *He was reportedly blindfolded with a scarf, stripped naked and* ***had his sexual organs squeezed.*** *He was also said to have been sworn at; beaten; threatened with death; sprayed with pressurized water and left near a ventilator; and* ***raped with a truncheon****.*[13]

The following example was coded as rape but not multiple perpetrator rape because the report was not sufficiently clear.

Example

Actor: **FDLR**
Country & Year: DRC (Zaire) 2009
Form: Rape

> *In another case in May, the FDLR abducted five women on their way to the market near Mihanda village in Ziralo. One of the victims told Human Rights Watch her attackers said, "You made us suffer. We've always been here, and now they're trying to chase us out. You, the mothers and fathers here, are complicit with the government forces, and because of that, we are going to punish you. Since you're Congolese, we can never pardon you."180 Then the* ***FDLR attackers raped the women****.*[14]

[13] Amnesty International, "Turkey: Appeals Cases: Students Reportedly Tortured for Submitting Petitions", March 2002, available at: http://www.amnesty.org/en/library/info/EUR44/017/2002/en
[14] Human Rights Watch, "You Will Be Punished": Attacks on Civilians in Eastern Congo, 13 December 2009, 1-56432-582-2, available at: https://www.refworld.org/docid/4b28ffa82.html

4.0 Qualitative Notes

4.1 Structure of qualitative notes

Qualitative notes on the details and context of sexual violence accompany the prevalence and multiple perpetrator variables. The qualitative notes report additional information from the source across five dimensions: (1) victim characteristics, (2) targeting, (3) attack timing, (4) attack location, and (5) witnesses.[15]

The notes often contain verbatim text from the sources and a parenthetical reference to the source from which the text was derived.

The SVAC and RSVAC Sources	State = U.S. State Department AI = Amnesty International HRW = Human Rights Watch

Some notes specify whether the information is from an annual or special topical report by Amnesty International or Human Rights Watch.

4.1.1 Bracketed classifications

Whenever possible, the source text is accompanied by a bracketed classification that summarizes and classifies the information.[16] See below for more information.

Example

Actor: **Haiti**
Country & Year: Haiti 1993
Form: Rape

Location Notes:	The prison in the army base in the larger town of St. Marc [detention] (HRW Special); in a home [private] (HRW Special)

In this example, the note is drawn from an observation in which the government of Haiti was reported to have engaged in sexual torture, rape, and forced abortion. The above note describes where the conflict actor perpetrated rape. The notations in brackets indicate that the incidents occurred in an official or unofficial detention facility (detention) and a private home or office (private).

[15] These dimensions are adapted from similar variables that were included in version 1.0 of the SVAC dataset.

[16] The qualitative notes in RSVAC are based on similar variables that were included in version 1.0 of the SVAC dataset. In SVAC version 1.0, the dataset had several text and dummy variables to capture information on the context of attacks, like Refugee (dummy variable) to indicate that victims included refugees and Location (text variable) to record where an incident took place. The bracketed notation in RSVAC is adapted from these SVAC dataset variables. See http://www.sexualviolencedata.org/archive/ to download version 1.0 of the SVAC dataset.

4.2 Multiple perpetrator notes

The qualitative note summarizes the reporting on multiple perpetrator incidents. The note may include such details as the reported number of perpetrators, the reported location of the sexual violence, any reported factors giving rise to the attack, the reported victim's gender and age, and whether the victim was reported to have been targeted. Where the multiple perpetrator score is coded as 2, the note indicates the reasons for this coding decision.

4.3 Victim notes field

For observations in which information on the victims of sexual violence was reported, this text field indicates whether the victims were

- children,
- men,
- detainees, and/or
- refugees.

Detainee is broadly defined to include any individual kept in captivity or taken into any form of custody. Additionally, if sexual violence was perpetrated by proxy, such information is included in this field.

In certain special circumstanced delineated below, the `victim notes` field captures certain other specific details about the incident(s).

The victim description in the qualitative notes field may pertain to one person or many persons, and each descriptor should be read independently of the others. For instance, the note 'male; detainee' does not necessarily indicate that the armed actor perpetrated sexual violence against a male victim in detention. Rather, the perpetrator attacked one or more male victims and one or more detained victims. The victim(s) may have been but was not necessarily both male and detained.

4.3.1 Sexual torture: reported gender of victims

When assembling the dataset the gender of sexual torture victims became an area of particular interest, as male victims were much more often reported to be targets of this form of sexual violence. The victim notes on sexual torture include more information on the gender of victims than victim notes on other forms. The notes indicate if victims were male only, female only, male and female, or if the gender was not specified in the reporting. The amount of information on the gender of sexual torture victims in the source reporting varies. Sometimes the sources give the gender of each victim in each reported sexual torture incident. At other times the sources report that sexual torture took place without providing information about the reported victims, including their gender.

Category (1) indicates that the sources identify the gender of each reported victim of sexual torture. This, of course, is not to say that the information about all sexual torture attacks in the conflict-actor-year is complete, but that of those attacks reported, the gender of the victims was identified.

All reports of sexual torture specify the gender of victim(s), and that gender is male, female, or male and female.

Victim notes	Male (1)	= Only male victims
	Female (1)	= Only female victims
	M/F (1)	= Male and female victims

Category (2) indicates that the source reporting was incomplete with regard to information on the gender of reported victims of sexual torture.

Some reports do not specify the gender of victim(s), but others do, and that gender is male, female, or male and female.

Victim notes	Male (2)	= Male victims
	Female (2)	= Female victims
	M/F (2)	= Male and female victims

The reports do not specify the gender of victims.

Victim notes	GNS	= Gender not specified

These seven codes are exclusive. Only one code appears in the victim notes for each observation reporting sexual torture. This note is applicable to the sexual torture worksheet only.

Example

Actor: **India**
Country & Year: India 1992
Form: Sexual torture

Victim Notes: Male (1); Detainee (AI)

We see in this example that the source reporting identified the gender of all reported victims of sexual torture, and the reported victims were exclusively male. We also see that detainees were reported to have been among the victims of sexual torture. This data came from Amnesty International.

4.3.2 Disaggregating sexual slavery and forced marriage

We identify in the `victim notes` field whether an actor was reported to have engaged in forced marriage, sexual slavery, or both forced marriage and sexual slavery. This note is applicable to the sexual slavery worksheet only.

Using this notation, we indicate reports of:

Victim notes	FM	= forced marriage only
	FM/SS	= forced marriage and sexual slavery
	[no note]	= sexual slavery only

Example

Actor: **MPIGO**
Country & Year: Cote d'Ivoire 2002
Form: Sexual slavery

Victim Notes: FM/SS; Detainee (HRW)

In this example, we see that there were reports of both forced marriage and sexual slavery and additionally that detainees were reported to have been among the victims.

4.3.3 Disaggregating forced abortion and forced sterilization

We identify in the `victim notes` field whether an actor was reported to have engaged in forced abortion, forced sterilization, or both forced abortion and forced sterilization. This note is applicable to the forced abortion worksheet only.

Using this notation, we indicate reports of:

Victim notes	FS	= forced sterilization only
	FS/FA	= forced sterilization and forced abortion
	[no note]	= forced abortion only

Our sources do not report any incidents of forced sterilization in the 1989-2015 period.

4.4 Targeting notes field

For observations in which targeting of victims was reported, this text field indicates the characteristic on which the victims were reported to have been targeted, including their

- ethnicity,
- nationality,
- religion,
- age,
- combat actor affiliation, or
- other trait.

In the conflict manuscripts, observations with non-zero prevalence values are accompanied by a table documenting the precise term or phrase underlying the coding decision. In this table, readers will see an imprecisely named field 'Selection Notes', which is equivalent `targeting notes`.

4.5 Timing notes field

For observations in which the timing of attacks was reported, this text field includes timing keywords, including, but not limited to, those pertaining to

- months,
- military operations (e.g. raids, attacks, retreats),
- political events (e.g. elections, regime change, negotiations),
- errands (e.g. collecting firewood, going to the field or market), and
- searches of a private space (e.g. home, office).

4.5.1 Sexual slavery: timing of abduction

For sexual slavery only, the text field includes a parenthetical note indicating whether the timing keyword pertains to the *moment of abduction*. This added specificity is intended to provide further context on the timing of attacks resulting in sexual slavery. This added detail accompanies only those observations in which the reporting contained sufficient information.

Example

Actor: **HSM**
Country & Year: Uganda 1989
Form: Sexual slavery

Timing Notes:	during raid of secondary school (moment of abduction) (State)

The entry in the timing notes field indicates that, according to the U.S. Department of State, victims of sexual slavery were abducted during a raid on a secondary school.

4.6 Location notes field

For observations in which the location of attacks was reported, this text field includes location keywords, including, but not limited to, those pertaining to

- camp (e.g. refugee or military camp),
- checkpoints,
- detention (e.g. police station, military barracks, prison),

- home or office, and
- schools.

If a location was public, semi-public, or private, this is indicated in a bracketed notation alongside the location keyword.

4.6.1 Sexual slavery: place of abduction and place of captivity

For sexual slavery only, the text field includes a parenthetical note indicating whether the location keyword pertains to the *place of abduction* or the *place of captivity*. This added detail accompanies only those notes in which the reporting contained sufficient information. The *place of abduction* may not be the place where sexual violence was perpetrated.

Example

Actor: **RUF**
Country & Year: Sierra Leone 1999
Form: Sexual slavery

Location Notes:	Freetown (place of abduction) (AI Annual); Cline Town area in the east of Freetown (place of abduction) (AI Special); Occra Hills region (place of captivity)

We see in the example that reported sexual slavery victims were abducted in Freetown generally, and specifically in the Cline Town area to the east, and we see that victims of sexual slavery were held in the Occra Hills region. This data is from Amnesty International annual and special reports.

4.7 Witness notes field

For observations in which information on witnesses of sexual violence was reported, this text field indicates whether the witnesses were

- family members,
- fellow victims,
- soldiers, or
- other types of people.

5.0 Structure of Dataset

Observations (conflict-actor-year) are divided into separate worksheets based on the form of sexual violence reported in the SVAC dataset. The observations were distributed across the worksheets using the SVAC `form` variable. Observations that include more than one form of sexual violence are duplicated so that they appear on each relevant worksheet.

Each form worksheet includes 1) all SVAC dataset variables and 2) the RSVAC variables and qualitative notes.

See the SVAC Coding Manual at http://www.sexualviolencedata.org/ for information on the SVAC dataset variables.

The RSVAC variables and notes are appended to the right of the SVAC variables. Each worksheet contains twelve RSVAC variables and notes, beginning with "SVAC form".

Table 4. RSVAC Variable Description and Notes

Variable Description	Variable Notes
`svac_form`	Text list. Reported forms of sexual violence coded in the SVAC dataset. Variable shows which forms were coded using the SVAC definitions of sexual violence. This variable is included to preserve transparency and comparability of SVAC and RSVAC. Users of the RSVAC dataset should rely on `rsvac_form` (see below) to determine the forms an actor engaged in.
`rsvac_form`	Text list. Reported forms of sexual violence coded in the RSVAC dataset. Variable was coded using definitions in Section 2.0 of the RSVAC Coding Manual. -99 is used where SVAC found reports of sexual violence but RSVAC found no reports of any form.
USSD prevalence	Numeric prevalence. Scale 0-3. Coded for each form using the annual U.S. State Department "Country Report on Human Rights Practices". -99 indicates no report found and no data available. On the sexual torture worksheet, sometimes there is a note to see a different tab; see Section 3.1.2 of the RSVAC Coding Manual.
AI prevalence	Numeric prevalence. Scale 0-3. Coded for each form using the annual reports and special topical reports of Amnesty International. -99 indicates no report found and no data available.
HRW prevalence	Numeric prevalence. Scale 0-3. Coded for each form using the annual reports and special topical reports of Human Rights Watch. -99 indicates no report found and no data available.
Multiple perpetrator prevalence	Numeric prevalence. Scale 0-2. Coded for each form using USSD, AI, and HRW.
MP notes	Text field. A qualitative note that summarizes the reporting on multiple perpetrator incidents.
Victim notes	Text field. A qualitative note that summarizes reported information on victim characteristics when information is available. Additionally, this field includes notation to disaggregate reports of sexual slavery and forced marriage and reports of forced abortion and forced sterilization.
Targeting notes	Text field. A qualitative note that summarizes reported information on victim targeting when information is available.
Timing notes	Text field. A qualitative note that summarizes reported information on the timing of sexual violence when information is available.

Location notes	Text field. A qualitative note that summarizes reported information on the location of sexual violence when information is available.
Witness notes	Text field. A qualitative note that summarizes reported information on witnesses of sexual violence when information is available.

6.0 Biases and Limitations

The RSVAC Data Package is subject to several potential biases and limitations. Please see the RSVAC article and online appendix for a discussion of tehese issues.